which was imminent. But, by remaining non-committal on my elevation, and his own continuance in ISRO, Rao made me think if he had a Machiavellian streak in him. Rao had made the tactical move to Bangalore to head the satellite centre so that he could be close to the headquarters. Indeed he was most qualified for the ISRO chairman's job, but he was not the only one.

Y J Rao, who should be credited with developing the Sriharikota Range (SHAR) could well have become the ISRO chairman before U R Rao, but for some unfortunate incidents and a cardinal mistake on Dhawan's part. Sriharikota was identified in 1969 for setting up launch pads and some auxiliary facilities. Within two years, a Rohini (RH-125) rocket was launched from here, marking its inauguration.

When acquired from the Andhra Pradesh Government, Sriharikota, a spindle-shaped island, was mostly uninhabited, with the Bay of Bengal on one side and the Pulicat lake, actually a lagoon, on the other three. The place almost perfectly suited ISRO's requirements as it was on the east coast and not too far from the equator. Some fishing hamlets on the sea side were the only signs of human habitation there. Being a deserted place added to the safety.

From laying a road from Sullurpet, the 'mainland', to setting up the launch facility, it was a Herculean task that ISRO teams captained by Y J Rao and a few others achieved in two years. Soon after the land acquisition, Sarabhai asked the seniors to come up with proposals for the facilities that could be set up there. Gowarikar came up with the idea of a solid propellant space booster plant (SPROB); Muthunayagam wanted a static test and evaluation complex (STEX); Y J Rao proposed the Rocket Sled Facility which included aerodynamics testing and launch facilities. Sarabhai approved all the projects.

A year after the first Rohini launch from SHAR in 1971, Y J Rao took over as its director and continued there for five years. He was a natural choice as Dhawan's successor, but a coterie, which was envious of his well-deserved rise was waiting for an opportunity to pull him down. These people had raised several allegations against Y J Rao, including that he was